Local SEO Masterclass

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Ranking a Local Google ...

Introduction to Local SEO

NAP Consistency + Map Emb...

Getting ONLY 5 Star Reviews f...

Getting a Google My Busines...

GMB Location + Direction Ma...

Rank and Rent (Organic S...

Introduction to Rank and Rents

Setting up a Rank and Rent

Ranking your Rank and Rent

Pricing your Rank and Rent

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Local SEO for Beginners (...

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Module 2: Setting Up Your Google Business Profile



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Overview: Google Business Profile – formerly **Google My Business (GMB)** – is the cornerstone of Local SEO. In this module, you'll learn how to create, claim, and verify a Google Business listing and optimize it for maximum visibility. A properly set up Google Business Profile is *essential*: without it, a company **won't show up in Google Maps or the local 3-pack** at all. Through step-by-step lessons, we'll guide you in populating every profile section with accurate information, selecting the best categories, and adding photos. Getting this profile right will dramatically improve your chances of ranking #1 in local searches.

Lessons:

We'll go through the official process: visiting the Google Business page, entering the business name and details, and choosing the correct business category (tip: *research competitor listings to see which categories they use for ideas*). You'll learn how to specify a physical address or

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service area, add contact details, and request verification (usually via postcard PIN, phone, or email). We emphasize using the **exact business name, address, and local phone number** you compiled earlier – consistency here (and later on other sites) is critical for Local SEO.

2. **Optimizing Your Business Profile Information** – Once the basic profile is up, it's time to fill in **every section**. We cover uploading a high-quality **profile photo or logo**, adding additional photos of the business (interior, exterior, team, products), setting correct hours, and writing a compelling business description. Google rewards complete profiles, so our motto is *no field left blank!*. You'll also learn the importance of choosing *precise, relevant categories* for the business – *categorize your business by what it actually does or offers (e.g. "Italian Restaurant" vs a vague "Restaurant")*. This ensures you show up for the right searches.

3. **Pro Tips for Standing Out** – In this lesson, we share a few extra tricks: naming your photos with keywords (instead of generic filenames) before uploading and regularly updating your profile with new posts or Q&A responses to keep it active. We'll also discuss the value of **Google Business Profile features** like adding special hours for holidays, enabling messaging, and utilizing the Products/Services section if relevant. These small optimizations can give you an edge over competitors who set and forget their profiles.

4. **Avoiding Common GMB Pitfalls** – Finally, we caution against some mistakes like keyword stuffing your business name (violates guidelines), using a virtual office or P.O. box as your address (Google may suspend for inconsistency), or neglecting the verification process (an unverified listing won't rank well). You can safely manage your client's profile without penalties by knowing what not to do.



- **Claim or Create Listing:** Go to **Google Business Profile** (at `google.com/business`) and click "Manage Now." Follow the prompts to find your business or create a new listing. Enter the **exact business name** and fill in the address (or service area) and phone number. Select the **most accurate**

category for the business (you can add secondary categories later, but the primary one is most important).

- **Verify Your Business:** Initiate Google's verification process. Opt for the available method (postcard by mail is common – Google will send a code to the business address which you'll later enter to verify). **Note:** It's crucial to complete verification – an unverified profile won't have full control or visibility. While waiting for a postcard, you can still proceed to fill out other details.

- **Complete Every Detail:** Log in to your Google Business dashboard and supply **all requested information**. Write a clear description of the business (mention the services and location), double-check hours of operation, and upload at least 5 photos (e.g., logo, storefront, team at work, products/services, and an attractive cover image). Name your image files with keywords (for example, `Seattle-Plumber-team.jpg` instead of `IMG0001.jpg`) to give Google extra context.

- **Optimize Your Info:** Ensure the business name, address, and phone (NAP) you entered match exactly how they appear on the website and other materials – consistency boosts your credibility in Google's eyes. Add additional categories if relevant, and set attributes (like "Wheelchair accessible" or "Outdoor seating") that apply. The goal is to have a **100% complete** profile – Google even shows a completion percentage, so aim for 100%.

- **Publish and Monitor:** Once verified, your listing can show up publicly. Search for it by name to see how it appears. Encourage the business owner to keep an eye on the profile – occasionally update photos, respond to any customer Q&A, and be ready to respond to reviews (we'll cover reviews in depth later). This proactive management can



populated Google Business Profile for the business. The company can now appear on Google Maps and in local search results. You've laid the single most important brick in the local SEO foundation – without a GMB listing, ranking in local search

is impossible. You can boost it further in upcoming modules now that it's live.